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Mrs. Hart

AP Literature

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Growing Upside-Down

In 2017, when I was nine years old, my family visited a giant sequoia grove near San Francisco. I had always loved wildlife, forests, and animals, but the feeling of being engulfed by hundreds of enormous red trees in person is something I cannot describe to anyone. They were older than countries and wide enough that you could drive straight through them! When we came home from the trip, my father ordered a sequoia sapling in the mail. It was only a couple inches tall, bright green, fragile, but full of potential.

Sequoias were not meant for New England winters, but I refused to accept that. I watered it daily, moved it into bigger pots until I could put it into our special little greenhouse, and watched it stretch a little taller each month. Then one January, a snowstorm buried it all. The whole greenhouse collapsed under the weight of the snow. A couple months later, when the snow thawed, I explored the wreckage. All the plants inside were crushed. My sequoia lay upside-down, dark brown, and stiff.

But I noticed one tiny branch just barely glowing a faint green. I knew I had to keep trying; I replanted it in new soil, and somehow it lived. Eight years later, it is thriving in my backyard. It's still just a few feet tall, but it keeps growing a little bit each year. It reminds me of myself: a small boy overcoming adversity, trying to rise in the wrong environment, learning to survive, yearning to thrive.